Mobile Money Outliers in Global Financial Inclusion (2024)

Pietro Zecca

2026-05-05

1 Mobile Money Outliers in Global Financial Inclusion (2024)

Mobile money — financial services accessed via mobile phone rather than a traditional bank — has expanded rapidly in the developing world, particularly in Sub-Saharan Africa. Yet adoption remains highly uneven across countries, with some nations leading the world while others in the same region remain severely excluded. This report uses the World Bank Global Findex 2025 to identify countries that are statistical outliers in mobile money adoption and overall financial inclusion, and examines what patterns emerge.

2 Data

The data come from the World Bank Global Findex 2025 (https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/globalfindex/download-data), a nationally representative survey covering financial inclusion indicators across over 140 economies in 2024. The unit of analysis is the country. The two key variables are `account_t_d` (total account ownership, share of adults) and `mobileaccount_t_d` (mobile money account ownership, share of adults). Countries missing mobile money data are excluded, leaving 80 countries with complete data. Mobile money data is missing for most high-income countries, where mobile money is negligible and the World Bank does not systematically track it.

Outliers are identified using z-scores: a country is considered an extreme outlier if its z-score exceeds ± 2 on either variable, placing it in approximately the top or bottom 2.5% of the distribution.

3 Results

The scatter plot reveals a striking geographic divide. Sub-Saharan African countries dominate the upper-left quadrant — mobile-first inclusion — with Kenya (90% total, 88% mobile) and Ghana as extreme positive outliers in mobile money, achieving inclusion primarily through non-bank channels. By contrast, Niger (15% total) and Chad (21% total) sit in the lower-left as extreme negative outliers, severely financially excluded despite being in the same macro-region as the mobile money leaders.

Mongolia emerges as an outlier from a different direction: near- universal account ownership (98%) achieved substantially through mobile money (64%), showing that middle-income countries can leapfrog traditional banking infrastructure. Lebanon stands out as a middle-income MENA country

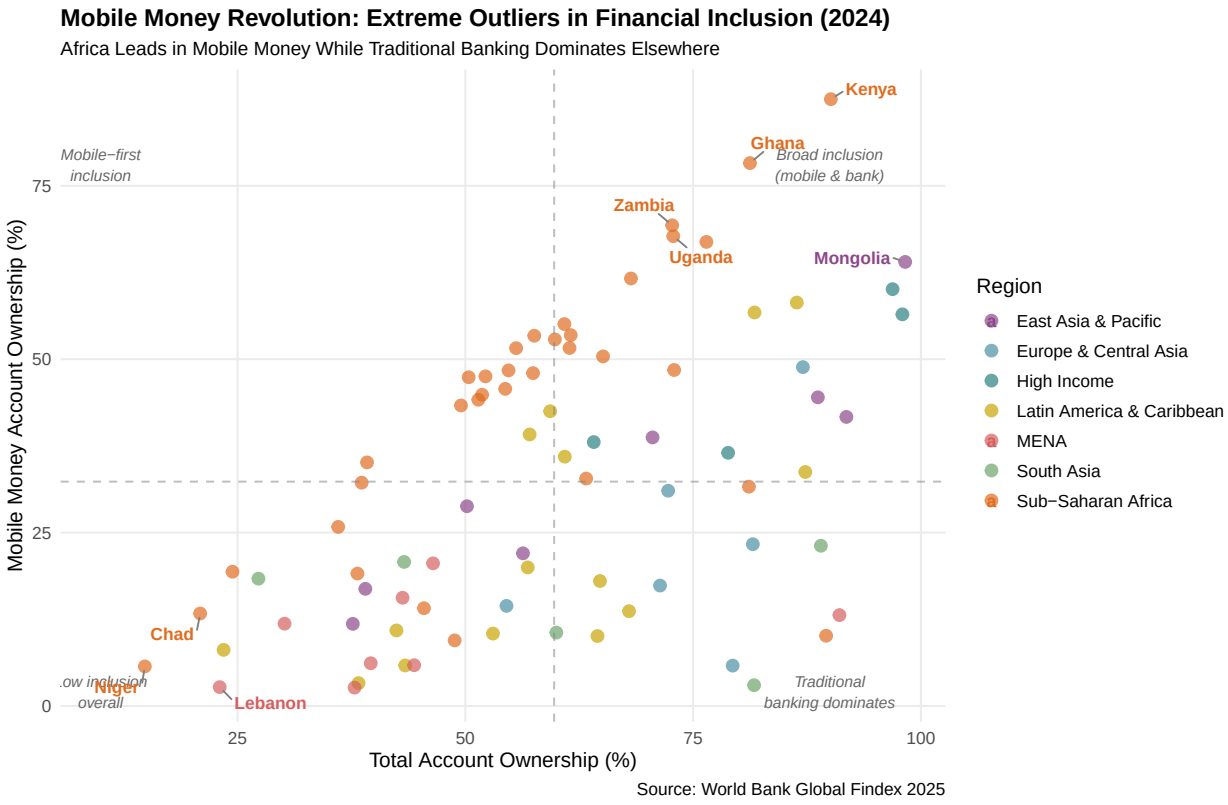

Figure 1: Total account ownership vs. mobile money account ownership by country, 2024. Dashed lines mark global averages (61% total, 31% mobile). Labeled countries are statistical outliers with z-scores exceeding ±2 on at least one variable. Sub-Saharan African countries (orange) dominate the mobile-first quadrant, while high-income countries (teal) cluster in the traditional banking quadrant.

with exceptionally low financial inclusion (23% total, 3% mobile), reflecting its ongoing economic collapse.

High-income countries (teal) cluster tightly in the lower-right — traditional banking dominant, mobile money near zero — consistent with the fact that the World Bank only collects mobile money data where it is relevant.

4 Conclusion

Mobile money has created a new pathway to financial inclusion, but adoption remains highly uneven. The countries leading the mobile money revolution and those most severely excluded often share the same region — Sub-Saharan Africa — revealing that geography alone cannot explain financial exclusion. Structural factors including regulatory environments, infrastructure, and conflict appear to drive the divergence. Understanding these outliers is increasingly relevant as the World Bank and United Nations target universal financial inclusion by 2030.